

BUDGIE · MELOPSITTACUS UNDULATUS

Keep your budgie the right way from day one.

A complete, checked-fact printable manual: cage setup, diet, handling, health triage, and the routines that keep a budgie thriving for its full lifespan.

20 pages

Beginner

Print or tablet

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Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

If you haven't set up yet

Read pages 4 through 8 in order before buying anything. Cage size and bar spacing are expensive and awkward to redo once your budgie is settled in. Get those right the first time, then use the Budget & Shopping List on page 14 to buy once.

If your budgie is already set up

Jump to the Setup Checklist and Temperature Targets on page 12 to audit what you have, and the Health Red Flags section starting on page 9 if anything seems off.

Print these first

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Page 12: Setup Checklist & Temperature Targets | ☐ Page 17: Daily & Weekly Routine |
| ☐ Page 13: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 18: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 16: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 19: Enrichment Checklist |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

Budgie husbandry advice online ranges from excellent to genuinely dangerous, and a lot of the outdated advice (seed-only diets, undersized cages) is still what many new owners hear first. This package reflects current cage-size, diet, and welfare standards, cross-checked against veterinary and avicultural sources, not recycled forum advice.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

An avian veterinarian. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care. Anything urgent or health-related is always a vet call, not a page in this book.

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail. [↩ BIRD](#)

Scientific name	Melopsittacus undulatus
Adult size	About 7 in (18 cm) nose to tail tip; 1 to 1.4 oz
Captive lifespan	5 to 8 years typical, up to 12 to 15 years in captivity with excellent care
Diet type	Pellet-forward, with fresh vegetables daily and seeds as a smaller part of the mix
Cage minimum	18×18×18 in for a single bird; 30×18×18 in for a pair. A floor, not a target
Temperature needs	65 to 85°F (70 to 75°F ideal); no special heating or cooling needed in a normal home
Social needs	Highly social flock bird; needs substantial daily interaction, or better, a compatible companion
Handling difficulty	Beginner; built on trust with a flighted bird, not physical restraint

Cost overview

Initial setup

\$175 to \$475 for a complete starter setup: cage, perches, dishes, and toys.

Monthly ongoing

\$5 to \$15 for a pellet-forward diet plus fresh vegetables.

BUDGET FOR THE FIRST YEAR TOO

First-year total cost of ownership, setup plus food, runs \$350 to \$900. That figure assumes routine care goes smoothly. Leave room beyond it for an unplanned avian vet visit.

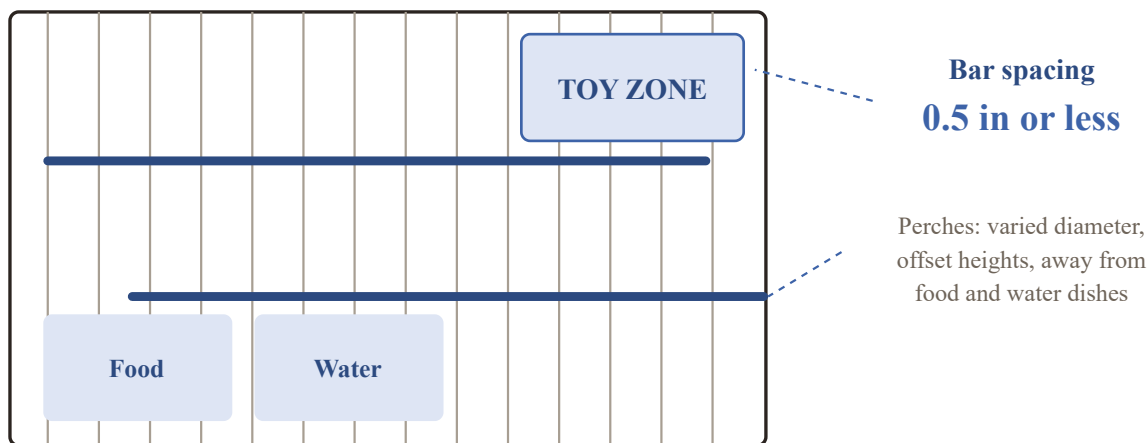
Fun facts worth knowing

- "Budgie" is short for budgerigar. In the wild, budgerigars are nomadic, moving across the Australian interior in large flocks in search of food and water.
- Budgies are strong mimics, and many individuals build a real vocabulary of words and sounds, though not every bird chooses to talk.
- The cere, the fleshy patch above the beak, is one of the more reliable ways to sex an adult budgie by sight: typically blue on males, and tan, brown, or pale pink/white on females.

SECTION 02 · FULL CARE GUIDE

Cage size & bar spacing

18×18×18 in is the absolute minimum footprint for a single budgie; 30×18×18 in for a pair. That's a floor, not a target, bigger is always better. Bar spacing needs to be half an inch (0.5 in) or less: wider spacing risks a head or wing getting caught, or a curious bird squeezing through entirely.



Cage floor: 18×18×18 in single bird minimum; 30×18×18 in for a pair.
Bigger is always better.

NEVER

Use bar spacing wider than half an inch (0.5 in). This is a known head-entrapment and escape risk, regardless of how roomy the rest of the cage looks.

What the diagram doesn't show

- Perches should vary in diameter and material, natural wood branches rather than uniform dowels, to exercise the feet and prevent pressure sores.
- Keep perches from sitting directly above food and water dishes. Droppings falling into either is a daily contamination problem, not an occasional one.
- Leave open space for a full wing stretch and a short flight hop between perches. A cage packed wall-to-wall with toys defeats the purpose of the extra size.
- Position the cage away from the kitchen, direct all-day sun, and cold drafts.

Diet & feeding

Budgies are seed-eating birds by ancestry, but "seed-eating" is not the same as "seed-only." A pellet-forward diet with fresh vegetables is what current guidance recommends, with seeds kept as a smaller part of the mix rather than the base of the diet.

COMPONENT	ROLE IN THE DIET
Formulated pellets	The base of the diet. Should make up the majority of what your budgie eats day to day.
Fresh vegetables	Offered daily alongside pellets. Adds moisture, fiber, and nutrients pellets alone don't fully cover.
Seeds	A smaller part of the mix, not the foundation. Seed-only diets are a major cause of fatty liver disease, see page 10.
Fresh water	Changed daily. Check that it hasn't been fouled by droppings or discarded food.

NEVER FEED SEED-ONLY

Seeds are high in fat and don't cover the broader nutrient profile a budgie needs. Seed-only feeding is one of the most common, and most preventable, causes of fatty liver disease in pet budgies. See page 10.

Making the switch to pellets

A budgie raised on seed can be reluctant to try pellets at first. Offer both side by side rather than switching overnight, and expect the transition to take patience. A bird that stops eating entirely during a diet change is a vet visit, not a wait-and-see situation.

Foods to avoid

Avocado, chocolate, caffeine, alcohol, and anything high in salt or sugar. None of these belong in a budgie's diet in any amount.

KEEP IT SIMPLE

A consistent pellet-forward routine with a small rotating selection of vegetables is easier to stick to, and easier to notice appetite changes against, than a diet that changes every day.

Handling & social needs

Budgies are highly social flock birds. In the wild they live and travel in large groups, and that instinct doesn't switch off in a cage. A single budgie needs substantial daily interaction from you, ideally spread across multiple short sessions, or is better off with a compatible budgie companion for company when you're not around.

Building trust with a flighted bird

Handling a budgie is nothing like handling an animal that just needs to tolerate being picked up. A budgie can leave the interaction entirely, so the goal is trust, not restraint. Move slowly, keep your voice calm and consistent, and let the bird choose to approach rather than reaching in to grab it.

BUILDING TRUST

Let your budgie come to you. Reaching into the cage to grab a bird reads as a predator strike, and it can cost you weeks of trust-building in a few seconds.

Step-up training

Most owners start with a finger or small perch offered at chest height, paired with a consistent cue word, and reward calm curiosity rather than pushing for immediate contact. Short, frequent sessions build confidence faster than long, infrequent ones.

If you have, or want, more than one budgie

Two budgies of similar size and temperament, introduced gradually in neutral territory, often do better together than a single bird kept alone. A companion doesn't replace your own interaction time, it supplements it.

First days in a new home

Give a newly arrived budgie a few quiet days to settle before attempting any handling beyond feeding and cage maintenance. Talk to it calmly near the cage so it gets used to your presence and voice before you ever open the door.

Common mistakes & enrichment

Mistakes that cause the most harm

- Keeping a single budgie with minimal daily interaction and no companion. Flock birds do not thrive in isolation.
- Feeding a seed-only diet because "that's what budgies eat," leading to fatty liver disease over time.
- Sizing the cage to the bare minimum and never upgrading, or choosing a cage on footprint alone without checking bar spacing.
- Placing the cage in the kitchen, in a drafty spot, or in direct all-day sun.
- Skipping toy and perch rotation, leading to a bored, understimulated bird.
- Assuming a fluffed-up, quiet bird is just resting instead of recognizing it as a possible early illness sign.
- Missing early signs of egg binding in a female because straining can look like normal nesting behavior at first glance.

Enrichment, by priority

Foraging

Hiding pellets or vegetable pieces inside foraging toys turns eating into a natural search-and-work behavior instead of a passive activity.

Chewing

Bird-safe wood, cardboard, and shreddable toys satisfy a natural chewing drive and help keep the beak in good shape.

Perch variety

Different diameters and textures across several perches exercise the feet and prevent pressure sores from a single uniform surface.

Training sessions

Short step-up and target-training sessions are mental exercise as much as physical, and they build the trust described on page 7.

Supervised out-of-cage time

Time outside the cage in a bird-proofed, supervised room lets a budgie stretch its wings. Never unsupervised, and never in a room with open windows, ceiling fans, or other pets.

Companionship

For a single budgie, your own daily interaction is the single biggest enrichment input there is. A compatible companion bird is the next best thing.

Health red flags

What to watch for, and what to actually tell the vet.

CONTACT AN AVIAN VET PROMPTLY IF YOU SEE

Open-mouth breathing or tail-bobbing with each breath, a fluffed-up and unusually quiet bird, crusty or honeycomb-textured patches around the beak or legs, an overweight body condition paired with lethargy, or a female straining without producing an egg.

What to tell the vet

- ☐ Diet breakdown (pellets vs. seeds vs. vegetables) over the last two weeks
- ☐ When symptoms started and whether they're worsening
- ☐ Changes in droppings, appetite, or activity level
- ☐ Whether the bird is female and currently laying, or has laid recently

Why diet and cage setup come up first

Most of the serious conditions in this section trace back to diet or setup more often than anything else: fatty liver from seed-only feeding, and egg binding linked in part to calcium and vitamin D deficiency. A vet will ask about food and setup before anything else for exactly that reason.

Normal vs. concerning

NORMAL	CONCERNING
Fluffed feathers briefly while resting or sleeping, then sleek again once active	Fluffed up and puffy for extended periods during normal waking hours
A quiet, low-key stretch of the day, especially around midday	Persistent lethargy, or a bird that won't leave the cage floor or a single perch
A healthy-weight, active female laying an occasional egg without difficulty	Straining, tail-bobbing, or lethargy around egg-laying, a possible sign of egg binding (page 11)

Fatty liver & scaly face mites

Fatty Liver & Obesity

Cause: seed-only or seed-heavy diets over time; seeds are calorie-dense and don't cover the broader nutrient profile a pellet-forward diet provides. **Signs:** an overweight body condition and lethargy. **Response:** diet correction under avian vet guidance, not a crash diet attempted on your own. **Related conditions:** lipomas and xanthomas, fatty growths that can develop alongside chronic obesity, are worth mentioning to your vet if you notice any lumps.

PREVENTION BEATS TREATMENT

A pellet-forward diet with fresh vegetables (page 6) prevents nearly all diet-driven fatty liver cases. This is the single highest-leverage decision in this whole package.

Scaly Face & Leg Mites

Cause: a mite infestation, spread through direct contact between birds. **Signs:** visible crusty, honeycomb-textured patches around the beak or legs. **Response:** vet-prescribed treatment. This condition is highly treatable once diagnosed, it's not a reason for panic, but it does need an actual vet visit rather than a home remedy.

DON'T WAIT IT OUT

Crusty patches around the beak or legs don't resolve on their own. The sooner treatment starts, the more comfortable your budgie is in the meantime.

Respiratory disease & egg binding

One applies to every budgie. The other only to females, but it's important enough to include.

Respiratory Disease

Signs: open-mouth breathing, tail-bobbing with each breath, and discharge from the eyes or nares. **What it can include:** a range of bacterial, fungal, and viral causes, among them psittacosis, a bacterial infection that is zoonotic (transmissible to people), part of why any respiratory symptom in a budgie deserves a prompt response rather than a wait-and-see approach. **Response:** a prompt avian vet visit. Don't try to diagnose the specific cause yourself, treatment differs by cause and a vet exam is how that gets sorted out.

Egg Binding

Female-only, and one of the true emergencies in this package. **What it is:** a condition where an egg cannot pass through the reproductive tract. **Linked to:** calcium and vitamin D deficiency and obesity, both diet and husbandry issues you have real control over. **Signs:** straining, lethargy, and tail-bobbing. **Response:** an immediate emergency vet visit. This is not a condition to monitor overnight and see how it looks in the morning.

EMERGENCY, NOT A WAIT-AND-SEE

If you keep a female budgie and see straining combined with lethargy or tail-bobbing, treat it as an emergency immediately. Egg binding can be fatal within hours to days if untreated.

Other conditions worth knowing by name

Megabacteriosis, also called avian gastric yeast, is a yeast infection of the digestive tract that a vet can test for. Goiter, an enlarged thyroid gland caused by iodine deficiency, is another condition worth naming if you notice changes around your budgie's neck or voice. Neither is covered in depth here, but knowing the name helps you describe what you're seeing.

THE COMMON THREAD

Diet and cage setup drive more of this health section than anything else: seed-only feeding, calcium and vitamin D shortfalls, and obesity. Get pages 5 and 6 right and you meaningfully lower the odds of ending up here.

Setup checklist & temperature targets

Essential setup checklist

- ☐ 18×18×18 in cage minimum, single bird (30×18×18 in for a pair)
- ☐ Bar spacing 0.5 in or less
- ☐ Multiple perches, varied diameter and material
- ☐ Food and water dishes positioned away from perches above them
- ☐ Foraging and chewable toys
- ☐ Consistent light/dark cycle, roughly 10 to 12 hrs darkness nightly
- ☐ Pellet-forward food plus fresh vegetables sourced before day one
- ☐ Cage cover or dedicated dark, quiet space for overnight rest

Temperature & environment targets

TARGET	RANGE
Room temperature	65 to 85°F
Ideal range	70 to 75°F
Special heating/cooling	Not needed in a normal home kept within the range above
Photoperiod	Roughly 10 to 12 hours of darkness at night
Cage size floor	18×18×18 in single; 30×18×18 in pair
Bar spacing	0.5 in or less

Before your budgie comes home

- ☐ Cage set up in its permanent location, away from kitchen, drafts, and direct sun
- ☐ Perches and dishes positioned so droppings don't fall into food or water
- ☐ Pellet-forward food and fresh vegetables lined up before day one
- ☐ A plan for a dark, quiet overnight spot in place

Emergency & quick targets

CALL AN AVIAN VET NOW IF

Open-mouth breathing or tail-bobbing with each breath · a female straining without producing an egg, especially with lethargy · overweight body condition combined with lethargy · crusty, honeycomb-textured patches around the beak or legs · a fluffed-up, unresponsive, or not-eating bird

READING	TARGET
Room temperature	65 to 85°F
Ideal range	70 to 75°F
Photoperiod	10 to 12 hrs darkness nightly
Cage size floor	18×18×18 in single / 30×18×18 in pair
Bar spacing	0.5 in or less

HAVE THIS READY WHEN YOU CALL

Diet breakdown over the last two weeks, when symptoms started, whether the bird is female and currently laying, and any changes in droppings, appetite, or activity level.

Budget & shopping list

ITEM	TYPICAL COST
Complete starter setup (cage, perches, dishes, toys)	\$175 to \$475
Total initial setup	\$175 to \$475
Pellet-forward food plus fresh vegetables (monthly)	\$5 to \$15
Monthly ongoing	\$5 to \$15
First-year total (setup plus food)	\$350 to \$900

PLAN FOR, DON'T COUNT ON AVOIDING

An emergency avian vet visit, for something like egg binding or a respiratory illness, is a real cost that isn't captured in the routine numbers above. A small emergency fund matters as much as any item on this list.

WHERE NOT TO CUT CORNERS

Cage size is the line item most directly tied to the health and behavior issues in this package. 18×18×18 in is a floor, not a target, and 30×18×18 in for a pair is the same. Save on toys and extras before you save on the cage itself.

First 30 days & days 31 to 90

Week 1

- ☐ Confirm cage size and bar spacing meet the minimums on page 12, not just "looks about right"
- ☐ Let your budgie settle: minimal handling, focus on feeding and observing appetite and droppings
- ☐ Schedule a wellness visit with an avian vet within the first couple of weeks

Week 2 to 3

- ☐ Begin short trust-building and step-up sessions if your budgie is eating and active normally
- ☐ Establish a consistent pellet-forward feeding routine
- ☐ Start the Owner Log on page 18

Week 4

- ☐ Review appetite, droppings, and activity trends from the Owner Log
- ☐ Introduce first enrichment items from page 19
- ☐ Confirm your light/dark routine is consistent, roughly 10 to 12 hours of darkness nightly

Days 31 to 90

- ☐ Book any follow-up wellness check your avian vet recommended
- ☐ Look back at the Owner Log for any slow drift in weight, appetite, or activity level
- ☐ Start rotating enrichment on the monthly schedule from page 19
- ☐ If your budgie is alone and you're considering a companion, introduce gradually in neutral territory (page 7)

Symptom quick reference

SYMPTOM	LIKELY CAUSE	ACTION
Overweight body condition + lethargy	Fatty liver / obesity	Vet + diet correction (page 10)
Crusty, honeycomb patches on beak/legs	Scaly face/leg mites	Vet-prescribed treatment (page 10)
Open-mouth breathing, tail-bobbing, discharge	Respiratory disease	Vet promptly (page 11)
Female straining, lethargy, tail-bobbing	Egg binding	Emergency vet immediately (page 11)
Fluffed up, unusually quiet	General illness sign	Vet promptly
Sudden drop in appetite	Several possible causes	Vet visit, bring the Owner Log (page 18)
Noticeable drop in activity level	Several possible causes	Vet visit, bring the Owner Log (page 18)
Feather plucking or excess preening	Stress, boredom, or a medical cause	Vet visit to rule out a medical cause first
Swelling near the neck or voice change	Possible goiter (page 11)	Vet visit
Weight loss between log entries	Several possible causes	Vet visit, bring the Owner Log (page 18)

Daily & weekly routine

Daily

- ☐ Check and refresh food and water
- ☐ Quick visual health check: droppings, activity level, appetite
- ☐ Interaction or out-of-cage time
- ☐ Wipe down dishes

Weekly

- ☐ Full cage liner change and wipe-down of perches and bars
- ☐ Weigh and log in the Owner Log
- ☐ Rotate or refresh one toy

Monthly

- ☐ Deep clean the cage and all accessories
- ☐ Review the Owner Log for trends, not just single readings
- ☐ Inspect perches for wear and droppings buildup

Seasonal

- ☐ Reassess room temperature swings between summer and winter, stay within 65 to 85°F
- ☐ Check that your light/dark routine is still consistent, roughly 10 to 12 hours of darkness nightly

Owner log

Photocopy this page, or track digitally. Consistency matters more than the format.

DATE	WEIGHT	APPETITE	DROPPINGS	ACTIVITY	NOTES

WHY BOTHER LOGGING

A steady trend in weight, appetite, droppings, and activity is the best early warning system you have. Most of the conditions in this package show up as a change in one of these before anything else is visible.

Equipment log

ITEM	LAST CHANGED/CLEANED	NEXT DUE
Cage liner		
Perch & toy rotation		
Water dish/bottle cleaning		

Vet visit log

DATE	REASON	FOLLOW-UP

Enrichment checklist

Setup

- ☐ Foraging toys in place
- ☐ Chewable/shreddable toys available
- ☐ At least two to three perches of varied diameter and material

Monthly review

- ☐ Rotate or reposition at least one toy
- ☐ Offer a training or foraging session beyond the daily routine
- ☐ Reassess whether perch spacing and toys still leave room for a full wing stretch

Enrichment log

DATE	ACTIVITY	HOW IT WENT

Glossary

Budgerigar	The full name for a budgie, a small parrot native to Australia's interior and commonly kept worldwide as a companion bird.
Cere	The fleshy area above a budgie's beak; typically blue on adult males and tan, brown, or pale pink/white on adult females.
Photoperiod	The daily cycle of light and darkness. Budgies do best with roughly 10 to 12 hours of darkness at night.
Fatty liver disease	A buildup of fat in the liver, most often caused by a seed-only or seed-heavy diet.
Scaly face/leg mites	A mite infestation causing crusty, honeycomb-textured patches around the beak and legs. Highly treatable with vet-prescribed medication.
Psittacosis	A bacterial infection that can accompany respiratory disease in birds and is zoonotic, meaning it can pass to people.
Egg binding	A life-threatening, female-only condition where an egg cannot pass through the reproductive tract.
Megabacteriosis	Also called avian gastric yeast; a yeast infection of the digestive tract.
Goiter	An enlarged thyroid gland caused by iodine deficiency.

Compiled from sources cross-checked against current Beastly Facts guides at time of publication. This package is a husbandry reference, not a substitute for an avian veterinarian, and is not a live website mirror. No external links or website CTAs appear in this document.

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